light of reality. According to Microsoft, Metro is the Windows Phone design language. It's called Metro because it's modern and clean. It's fast and in motion. It's about content and typography. And it's entirely authentic. If you noticed the subtle irony in this we can really examine these claims in the light of what Microsoft has actually accomplished with Windows Phone, some interesting trends emerge.

Modern and clean

The Metro user experience breaks with conventional thinking in the smart phone space and provides a UI that is modern and clean, or as I like to think of it, a UI that "gets out of the way." If you've been around the tech space for a while, you know that this is how Mac fans describe Mac OS X and make the inevitable comparison with the busier Windows. This time, however, the tables are reversed, and it is Microsoft, not Apple, with the cleaner, less busy design. So the Metro user experience is simple by design. It features a lot of white space, or larger than expected areas of onscreen real estate that are left devoid of onscreen controls, in a nod to design simplicity. Microsoft says that Windows Phone has undergone a "fierce reduction of unnecessary elements" in the user interface. This is not a busy UI by any stretch of the imagination. This focus drives home Microsoft's point that a Windows Phone is not a tiny PC, as were all previous Windows Mobile, Pocket PC, and Windows CE devices.

It is instead something else, something unique given its size and form factor. And this way of thinking differentiates Windows Phone from the iPhone and Android competition: Those phones work very much like mini-PCs, offering It is instead something this way of thinking competition. Those phones work an application-based experience where you must dive in and out of separate, siloed experiences.

Fast and in motion

While the iPhone and other smart phones offer some modicum of animation and mini-design flourishes that resemble a page turning or flipping up from the corner, Windows Phone deeply integrates animation and motion into the user experience, providing visual cues and feedback about the actions you make. And these animations and motion move at a rapid clip, thanks to the underlying power of the device's CPU and GPU (graphics processing unit). There are transition animations as you launch applications, move between screens, or accomplish tasks. Considering the Spartan nature of